

a RETOLDLY artifact.

The Founder's *Carousel Playbook*

Turn your existing content into LinkedIn carousels that get saved and convert.

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A QUICK NOTE

Hello, Founder with the bag of ideas.

Let me be straight with you about what this playbook actually is.

It's not a list of "5 carousel hacks" you can skim in two minutes, or a Canva tutorial. There are plenty of those online, and most of them won't change anything about how your content performs.

This is **the framework I built Retoldly around**.

Over the last 7 years, I've written 1,000+ articles, edited 500+, and designed 150+ carousels. What I've learned from this hands-on experience is that most writing/repurposing work out there is hurried copy-paste that buries the juice of your thought-leadership in unnecessary sentences nobody needs.

Everything is done fast-paced. That's the content world, and I get it.

Nobody slows down between the original content and the carousel itself to extract the key elements the audience actually benefits from.

That "slowing-down" is the whole job, **and that's what I'm walking you through here**.

What you're getting

- A real, end-to-end framework for repurposing your content into carousels that get saved.
- A first-draft process for those starting from a blank page, even if you've never written before.
- Repurposing moves and editorial checks I run on every piece before any design happens.
- Design fundamentals so you understand the craft behind each design.
- A pre-publish checklist you should use before you hit post.

How to read this

You can read it cover to cover (in about 30 minutes). Or you can jump to the section you need most right now; each section stands on its own.

By the end, you'll either have everything you need to run this yourself, or you'll know exactly why outsourcing makes more sense for you. *Both outcomes are wins.*

Let's get into it.

Glory-Anna

INSIDE THIS PLAYBOOK

What you'll find.

*This playbook follows two paths: **Repurposing existing content into a carousel** and **drafting one from scratch**.*

Here we go:

01 Before You Start: Audit Your Content

What can be repurposed, what should be, and what to do if you have nothing yet.

02 The First Draft

How to draft a carousel script from a blank page.

03 The Repurposing & Editorial Layer

The full sequence, from translation to pressure-testing the script.

04 Designing the Carousel

Brand foundations, typography, layout, color, etc.

05 The Pre-Publish Checklist

A printable checklist you can save and use before every repurposing.

06 DIY vs Outsource?

An honest take on when to do this yourself vs when to hand it over.

SECTION 01

Before You Start: Audit Your Content.

Most founders skip this step and end up paying for it. They pick a piece of content (usually the wrong one), spend hours trying to repurpose it, and end up with a carousel that doesn't connect with the audience because the source material wasn't carousel-friendly to begin with.

Auditing your existing content takes roughly 20 minutes and saves you tons of hours. **Here's how I do it for new clients.**

What can be repurposed?

Almost any long-form content can become a carousel, though some translate more naturally than others:

- Blog posts, articles, industry reports
- Podcast transcripts (especially those with clear arguments or frameworks)
- YouTube videos and webinars (transcripts)
- Newsletter issues
- Keynote speeches and conference talks
- Workshop or course materials
- Long LinkedIn text posts that performed well
- Internal docs that contain real thinking (memos, strategy decks, frameworks)
- Voice notes you've recorded for yourself
- Even meeting recordings, if there's a real argument inside them

The carousel candidate test

Not every piece of content makes a great carousel — but that doesn't mean it's unusable. Some content has carousel material, even if the entire piece won't translate. Other pieces can be reused almost in full. Both can work.

These five questions help you decide which path a piece is on:

1. Is the piece about one clear argument or insight? If it's making 6 unrelated points, it's probably likely six carousels, not one.
2. Does it contain at least one screenshot-worthy point? A line that someone might quote, save, or share without context can strengthen your carousel.
3. Is the thinking or idea still relevant? (Not all long-form content stays evergreen.)
4. Could you summarize the main idea in one sentence? If you can't, the piece probably needs more whittling down before it can become a carousel.
5. Has it already performed well somewhere else? If a podcast episode or blog post resonated with your audience, that's a strong candidate. You already have proof the idea works.

RETOLDLY TIP

When clients send me 5 pieces and ask which to start with, I always look for the strongest argument or framework. The strongest idea is what readers come for, and what we build the entire carousel around. Even if the thoughts feel rough around the edges, if there's a real point underneath, they can be refined until they work.

What to do if you have no existing content

If you're reading this and realizing you don't have a deep library to repurpose from, you're not stuck. I offer two paths you can take:

- **Path one:** Start with one. Write one detailed long-form post on a topic you know deeply. It can be:
 - a LinkedIn article,
 - a newsletter issue,
 - a Substack piece

That single piece can produce 3–4 carousels if you slice it right. It can also be repurposed into multiple forms of content for other platforms. See an example:

Content Type	Can Become?
LinkedIn long text post	LinkedIn and IG Carousel, IG reel script, Threads and Tweets, Talking points for a podcast, newsletter copy, etc.

- **Path two:** Build the carousel script from scratch using Section 02 (**The First Draft**) below. Then jump straight to point 04 of Section 03 ("Defend every claim") to start editing your carousel script.

SECTION 02

The First Draft.

This section is for you if you've exhausted your written content and you're starting from a blank page. *If you have existing content to repurpose, you can skip ahead to Section 03.*

Drafting a carousel from scratch doesn't need you to be the best writer. This is where many founders tend to get stuck.

Carousels, in their real sense, are designed to help you share deep points that usually remain in article or podcast format in a low-pressure way with your audience.

What you really need to do is get your thinking out of your head and into a structure the reader can actually follow.

Five steps that always work for me:

01 — Research the points.

Before you write a single word, get clear on what you want to say. Read what others have already published on the topic. Skim the comments under those posts; you'll find the real questions your audience is asking.

Your goal: **find the gap.**

What's missing from the conversation? What angle hasn't been covered? What do you have a stronger or different opinion on? That's your contribution, and your carousel's reason to exist.

02 — Brain dump everything you know.

Open a blank doc and write down every thought, opinion, story, statistic, framework, or example you have on the topic. Don't edit yet. Don't worry about order or quality. Just empty the bag.

Write fast. If a thought stops you, write it down too. The point of this step is volume, not polish. You'll cut and shape later.

RETOLDLY TIP

If you struggle with writing, talk it out instead. Record a 3–5 minute voice note explaining the topic to yourself out loud. Transcribe it. You'll often find your strongest insights buried in the way you naturally speak.

The last carousel I shared on Instagram a few days ago came from a 3-minute voice note I transcribed and put on a design. The engagement from that carousel surpassed what I usually got from even my deeply researched educational carousels.

So, relax. You can do this.

03 — Build an outline from the dump.

Now look at your brain dump and find the spine. This is the strongest argument, framework, or central idea hiding inside it. That becomes your carousel's thesis.

From there, identify the 4–6 supporting points that move your reader from “wait, what?” to “ohh, that makes sense.” Each of those becomes a slide or a slide group.

Arrange the points based on this simple outline structure I swear by:

1. **Hook:** the strongest, most attention-grabbing point from your dump. Tweak until it sounds like you.
2. **Setup:** why this point matters or why most people get it wrong.
3. **Main points:** 3–5 distinct ideas that make your case and present your opinion.
4. **Resolution:** the takeaway, the shift, the next step.
5. **CTA:** what you want the reader to do next.

04 — Add short supporting points under each outline item.

Now go back to each outline point and add 1–3 short notes under it. Broaden the specifics that prove or expand the point. These are the lines that will eventually live on the slides.

Keep it tight, no need to ramble for carousels. **Each supporting point should be one or two sentences at most.** If it needs more, it's probably not a supporting point. Consider giving it its own slide.

05 — Add a CTA.

Don't leave the closing slide as an afterthought. Decide before you draft what you want the reader to do at the end — save, comment, click, follow, DM. The CTA shapes the entire carousel's tone.

Write the CTA in your outline first. *Then build the carousel toward it.*

Example In Practice.

Topic: Why workout supplements aren't necessary if your diet is right.	
Outline	Points
Hook	<i>Most workout supplements are solving a problem your fork should be fixing.</i>
Setup	<i>The supplement industry is worth \$61 billion globally, and it's built on the idea that you can shortcut what your meals are supposed to do. I don't believe that. Here's why...</i>
Main Points (You develop each)	↳ <i>Most pre-workout fatigue is undereating. A handful of dates and peanut butter does what a \$40 powder claims to.</i> ↳ <i>Protein powder is convenience sold as magic. If you're hitting your protein</i>

	<i>targets through food, you don't need it.</i> ↳ <i>Recovery "stacks" don't outperform sleep, water, and a real meal. They cost more, though.</i>
Resolution	<i>Fix the diet first. If you still feel like something's missing after 60 days of eating right, then talk to someone about supplements, but never before.</i>
CTA	<i>Send this to the friend who keeps spending \$200 a month on powders. Or comment REAL MEAL for my 30-day pre- and post-workout diet plan.</i>

Pretty easy, right?

Once your draft is done, you're ready to edit for clarity and tightness. Jump to point **04 of Section 03** ("Defend every claim") and run your script through the editorial checks.

The first three points of Section 03 are repurposing-specific. You can skip them since your script isn't from existing content.

SECTION 03

The Repurposing & Editorial Layer.

This is where the work happens. **Here's how I take a draft and turn it into a carousel-ready script.**

HOW TO USE THIS SECTION

If you're repurposing existing content (blog post, podcast, etc.), work through all seven points in order. If you came here from Section 02 (The First Draft), skip the first three points and start at point 04.

The first three are repurposing-specific, so they don't apply to a draft you wrote from scratch.

01 — Move the strongest insight to slide one.

This is the single most common mistake I see in most carousels. If the best line, the sharpest insight, or the boldest claim is buried on slide 5, you lose three-quarters of readers. You haven't given them a reason to stay or whet their appetites enough to keep swiping through.

In a blog post, you can bury the lead in paragraph 9 without losing your audience; readers committed to finding answers will dig (*this is arguable, but still forgivable for a blog post*). In a carousel, slide 5 is too late. The reader has already swiped past.

Your strongest insight should be on slide 1. That's your hook.

You can reorder the rest around it. Think of it like when creators start with the funniest part of a video to capture your attention, then rewind to the beginning once you've stopped to watch.

Example In Practice.

A founder's blog post titled "How We Hit \$1M ARR in 18 Months for X company" kept this line in paragraph 6: "We didn't hire a single salesperson until \$500K MRR."

That line became slide 1. The carousel hit 30K impressions.

Why? The statement is mind-boggling. Everybody wants to know how they achieved that.

02 — Cut 70% of the words.

A 2,000-word blog earns every paragraph and every line. A 10-slide carousel can't carry the same density, and most especially, must not have fluff or generic statements.

The skill is knowing which 70% to cut without losing the argument or flow of thought.

SPOILER: It's almost never the parts you're most attached to. The hardest cuts are sometimes the right ones.

What to keep

- The core argument and supporting evidence.
- The specific examples and numbers that back up your claim.
- The lines that would trigger saves or screenshots.

What to cut

- Throat-clearing transitions (“In this post, we’ll explore…”).
- Generic context the reader already has.
- Anything that sounds smart but doesn’t advance the argument.
- Most adverbs.

How to check

Read each sentence and ask: “Would I stake my name on this line if it stood alone on a slide?”

Examples of Filler Lines.

“Authenticity is everything.”

“Quality content matters.”

“This approach drives results.”

They sound right but say nothing. Either replace them with something specific, like “My first 100 customers came from one viral LinkedIn post,” or cut them out entirely.

03 — Pressure-test the swipe.

It’s one thing for a script to flow on the page. It’s another for it to hold up across the swipe gap.

Carousel readers are not very patient. They’re likely on a social platform like LinkedIn and have the next slide deck waiting to consume. If there’s a mental gap between slides, or something feels disconnected, they hop to the next user’s slide. Then you wonder why your post did poorly.

Every slide must do two things: stand alone (the point sticks), and connect to the next (the swipe is earned).

How to check

Read just the headline of each slide in order. Does the argument still make sense? Does each slide’s point follow meaningfully from the last?

If a reader picks up your carousel mid-swipe and still understands what’s going on, you’ve passed this check.

RETOLDLY TIP

Long-form earns the slow build. Carousels need the punch first. Treat the first slide like a magazine cover, not an essay introduction.

Example In Practice.

Slide 2 makes a claim. Slide 3 introduces a new concept that wasn't set up. The reader's brain trips. They don't know how to articulate what just happened, so they just disengage. Every slide must move the reader forward and still make sense on its own.

04 — Defend every claim.

Premium founder content must be built on credibility signals. One unsourced claim or fabricated stat, and your reputation takes a small but lasting hit.

This one is becoming increasingly common with the rise of AI. It's not uncommon for most artificial intelligence tools to cook up a hallucinated stat to back up their claims. In fact, [one famous CEO](#) recently got fined for two dozen cases of hallucinated citations in a court filing. *Oops.*

You don't want to trend for the wrong reasons, given your reputation. Which is why, if you use an AI tool to refine your brain dump, every stat or claim included must be a verified fact with proof.

How to check

Read the script slowly. For every number, percentage, or factual claim, ask:

"Could I cite the source for this if someone asked me right now?"

If yes, keep it.

If no, either add a source, soften the claim ("55% of experts argue..." becomes "in my experience..."), or remove it.

WATCH OUT FOR

Anything that sounds confident but is unverifiable. AI-generated drafts especially love confident-sounding fabrications. "95% of founders agree..." Do they, though? Where's that data from?

05 — Give the text a visual support system.

Some ideas can't survive in text alone. For instance:

- A multi-step framework.
- A counterintuitive insight.
- A comparison.

Long-form text relies on rhythm, cadence, and sentence length to illustrate its points to the reader. Carousels don't really have that luxury, so visuals are a big help.

How to check

As you read each slide of your script, ask: "If I read this aloud to someone, would a diagram make things easier? Are the points bulky and complicated?"

Anywhere the answer is yes tells you there's a visual need in the carousel. A simple illustration can bring your point home. If a slide needs visual support, it has to get one, or you risk losing your audience.

IDEAS THAT ALMOST ALWAYS NEED VISUALS

Step-by-step processes.
Before/after comparisons.
Frameworks with multiple parts.
Anything involving relationships between concepts.

06 — Give the reader somewhere to go.

Carousels without a final next step have only done half of the work. Closing on a nice thought could fly in a newsletter to your fans. But if you want your carousel posts to work for you while you sleep, maximize the real estate space at the end.

Your last slide should either trigger a save, spark a comment, or send readers somewhere. **If it doesn't, the carousel didn't do its job.**

Three closing-slide patterns that work

- 1. The summary recap.** Reinforce the core idea and add a "save this" reminder, so the reader can save or download the carousel for reference.
- 2. The provocation.** Ask a quirky/triggering/interesting/chaotic/goading question that demands a response in the comments.
- 3. The redirect.** Send them to the original long-form content or even a redirect to an offer (e.g., "full breakdown on the blog," "links in the caption," comment **YO'MAMA** to get the link to my sleep routine).

07 — Read it out loud. Listen for your voice.

This is my last check before I move into design.

Read your script out loud, slide by slide. Two things happen at once when you do this:

→ First, you hear how it sounds to a reader.

- Clunky lines reveal themselves.
- Sentences that looked fine on the page suddenly trip you up when spoken.

→ Second, you hear whether it actually sounds like you.

This part matters more than most founders think, especially if you've previously built a presence on camera or video. Your audience already knows what you sound like, so if a slide sounds different from you, it raises flags before the reader can articulate why.

This is especially important when AI helps with refining the draft.

Look closely at any sentence that doesn't sound like something you'd actually say to a follower, to a camera, or in real life. Take that line and swap it for one that sounds like you.

THE TWEAK CAN BE AS TINY AS:

"The research is groundbreaking." → "The research is solid."

Same thing, but the voice is different. The second version is one a human would actually say. The first version sounds like a press release.

That mini-tweak is the difference between readers swiping through your carousel without friction and readers raising eyebrows because something feels off.

SECTION 04

Designing the Carousel.

Most founders think design is about the tool. **It's really about decisions.** What's your typeface/font? What are your colors? What's on every slide and what's never on a slide? The decisions you make before opening any tool are what make a carousel feel premium.

Here are a few design basics worth understanding before you design your next one.

Brand foundations

Visual consistency and simplicity matter more than visual complexity for carousel design. A carousel with three colors and one font, used the same way every time, will outperform a carousel with twelve clever design choices that don't connect.

Pick three things and stick to them

→ Two fonts maximum. My go-to is one serif for headlines and one sans serif for body text. (Or two sans serifs in different weights.)

→ Three colors at most. One background color, one primary text color, one accent.

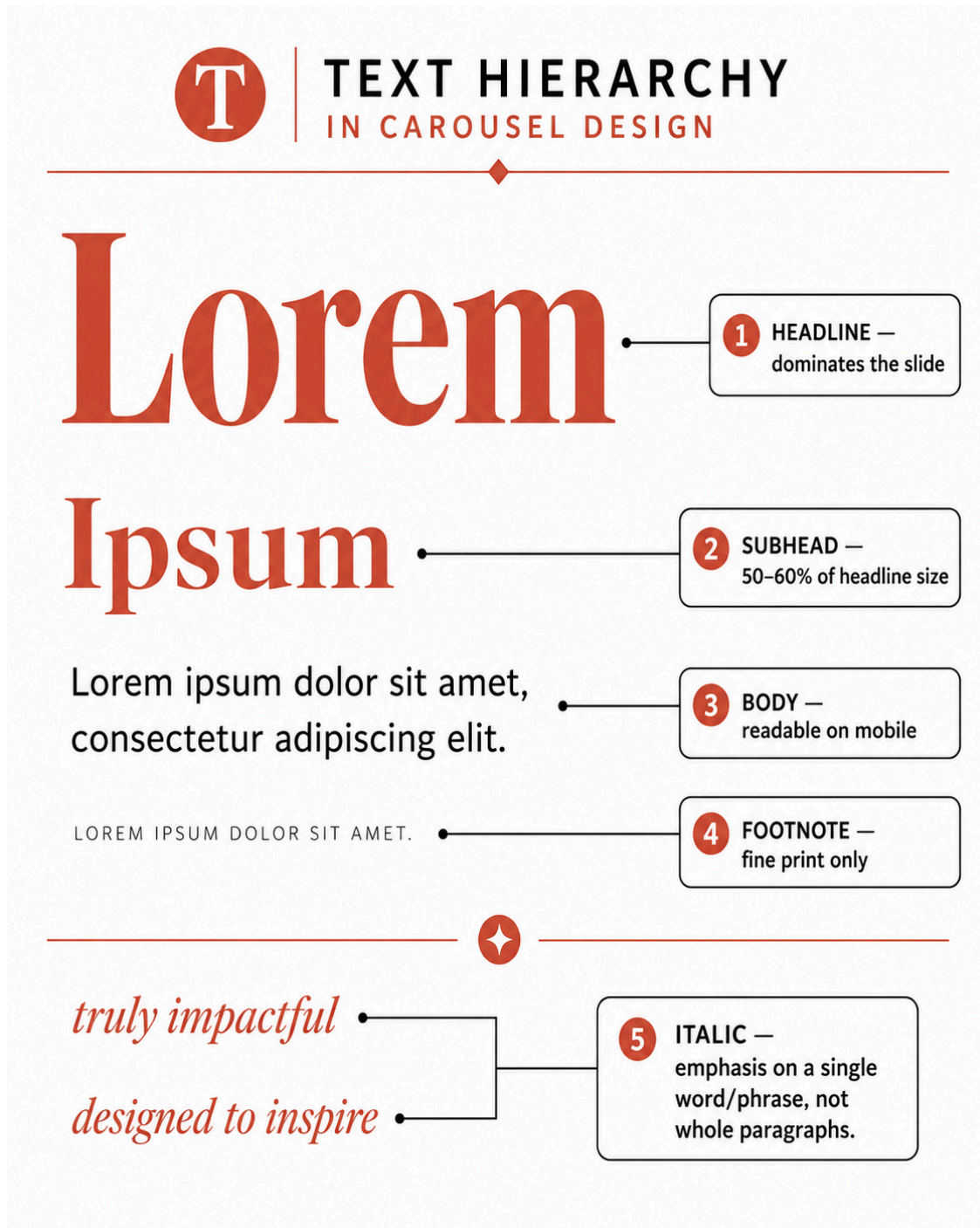
*("Accent" = the one bold color you use sparingly to draw the eye to what matters most, such as a key word, a stat, a callout. Can you guess what **Retoldly's** accent color is?)*

→ One signature element. A watermark, a logo placement, a recurring shape... something that appears on every carousel and tells the reader, "this is from my brand."

TIP

If you can't name your three colors and two fonts off the top of your head, you don't have a brand system yet. You're still building your vibe. Make your choices now and lock them in.

Typography essentials



Hierarchy is the whole game

A reader scanning a slide should know within half a second what the most important element is. That happens when type sizes are clearly different.

- **Headline:** Large enough to dominate the slide. Often 60–80pt for a key slide, depending on the font choice.
- **Subhead:** Secondary supporting text. It should be roughly 50–60% of the headline's size.

- **Body:** 18–24pt. To make it readable on mobile.
- **Footnote/source/fine print:** 12–16pt.

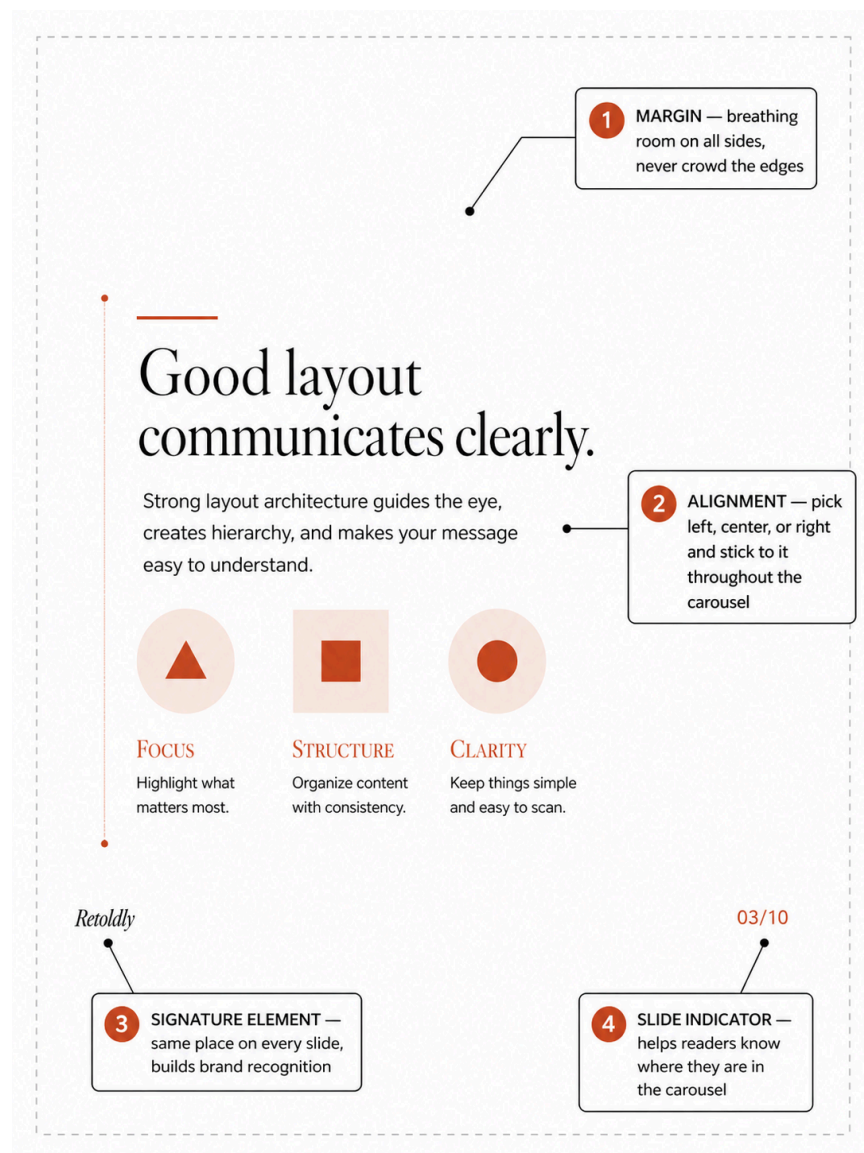
Use italic for emphasis, not decoration

Italics work hardest when they pull a single word or phrase out of a flat sentence. Don't italicize full paragraphs, or it gets exhausting to read.

Line length matters

Aim for 30–60 characters per line. Anything longer is hard to scan on mobile. Anything shorter starts to feel choppy.

Layout architecture



There's an invisible grid behind every premium carousel. Once you get the hang of it, you don't need to think about it consciously, but you do need to make sure your elements line up. The image above will show you how.

Three principles to follow

- 1. Margin discipline.** Leave breathing room. You'll be tempted to fill every pixel; resist it. Padding is what makes a slide feel premium. Give some space between each line and also between paragraphs.
- 2. Alignment.** Pick left, center, or right, and stick to it throughout the carousel. Mixed alignment makes slides feel chaotic without your reader being able to articulate why.
- 3. Consistency across slides.** The same elements should appear in the same place on every slide (your watermark, your name/brand name, your slide numbers, your logo). Readers register this subconsciously, and it builds your brand.

When to use what visual

- **Charts:** When you're showing change over time, comparison, or proportion.
- **Illustrations:** When you're explaining a concept that's hard to photograph. It's usually the right call for B2B abstractions. Also helps if you want your carousel to have a more human and less strict feel.
- **Photos:** When you need emotional weight, proof, or authenticity. Use sparingly.
- **Typography-only:** when the words themselves are the point, e.g, a single quote, a punch line, a moment that can stand all on its own.

Color rules that don't make sense until you've broken them

- **One accent is almost always enough.** Two competing accents fight each other.
- **Contrast over variety.** A reader can read white-on-dark or dark-on-light, but not tan-on-cream. Use legible colors on your background.
- **Save your boldest color for what matters most.** If everything is highlighted, nothing actually is.

The sign-off slide

Every carousel needs a closing slide that does the heavy lifting. Not a polite "thanks for reading." The closing slide must convert the reader's attention into action.

What a strong sign-off includes (For most founders, I use all three.)

- A clear next step (comment, follow, click, share).
- Your face or signature mark (humanizes the work).
- A reason to act now (you have something for them, you're open to questions, etc.).

SECTION 05

The Pre-Publish Checklist.

Run your draft against this checklist before you hit publish. If you can answer yes to every question, your carousel is ready.

Print this page or save it. It's the single most useful artifact in this playbook.

First Draft (skip if repurposing)

- ☐ Have I researched the topic and found my unique angle?
- ☐ Does my outline have a clear hook, supporting points, and a CTA?
- ☐ Have I added 1–3 short supporting points under each outline item?

Repurposing (skip if drafting fresh)

- ☐ Is the strongest insight on slide 1 (not buried)?
- ☐ Have I cut roughly 70% of the words from the original?
- ☐ Does every slide stand alone AND earn the next swipe?

Editorial (everyone)

- ☐ Can I cite the source for every number, percentage, or factual claim?
- ☐ Does every line on every slide earn its place? Have I cut all generic filler?
- ☐ Does the argument hold across the swipe?
- ☐ Could a reader pick it up mid-swipe and still understand?
- ☐ Have I identified the slides that need visual support?
- ☐ Does the closing slide give the reader a clear next step (save, comment, click)?

Design

- ☐ Am I using no more than 2 fonts and 3 colors across the carousel?
- ☐ Is there a clear typographic hierarchy on every slide (headline, body, footnote)?
- ☐ Is alignment consistent within and across slides?
- ☐ Does my signature element (watermark, logo, mark) appear on most slides?
- ☐ Have I left enough breathing room? (No slide should feel cluttered.)

Final

- ☐ Does the cover slide stop the scroll?
- ☐ Have I read the carousel out loud, slide by slide, and confirmed it sounds like me?

- ☐ Is the caption written separately (not a recap of the carousel)?
- ☐ Have I let it sit overnight before publishing? (Optional, but I recommend it.)

SECTION 06

DIY or Outsource?

If you've read this far, you have everything you need to run this process yourself. **The question is whether you should.**

Should you do this yourself?

Yes, if...

- You enjoy writing and have time to spend on it.
- You're building a personal practice and want to develop the craft.
- You publish infrequently enough (1–2x per month) that the time investment makes sense.
- You have a strong editorial eye already and just needed a framework.

Signs your time is better spent elsewhere

- You've been "about to start posting carousels on LinkedIn" for six months.
- You publish content elsewhere (blog, podcast, YouTube) but never get around to repurposing.
- You've tried before, didn't love the results, and shelved the whole idea.
- Every hour you spend designing a carousel is an hour not spent doing what only you can do for your business.

If you've read this and still feel out of your depth, **you have a time and craft problem**, and that's exactly what I built Retoldly for.

How to work with me

Retoldly offers two service tiers:

- 1. Design Studio (You write. I design.):** You send the content, I do the editorial review and full design treatment. From \$150 per carousel.
- 2. Fully Retold (I write & design.):** You share an idea or long-form piece, I handle everything from copy to final design. From \$350 per carousel.

Monthly retainers from \$1,500/month for founders posting consistently.

Your idea. My hands. Visit retoldly.com to start.

SEE WHAT FOUNDERS ARE SAYING

“This might just be the best carousel I’ve EVER laid my eyes on. It’s wayyy too good! The way you structured the copy, the colors, everything is super professional.”

What would have taken her the most time if she’d done it herself:

“If I had tried turning my newsletter into a carousel myself, I would have spent an ungodly amount of time figuring out what ‘vibe’ to take with the design, how to structure fonts, and what elements to include.”

The final result vs. what she expected:

“The final carousel script and design were beyond anything I would have ever hoped for. There was barely any brief, so to say I’m impressed is an understatement.”

What she’d say to other founders considering this:

“Definitely go for it. Your content would be 10,000 times better with an editorial-led design support firm like Retoldly.”

— Favour Agari

Founder, what’s the context? 🧐

BEFORE YOU GO...

Thank you for reading.

Most lead magnets are skim-fodder. I wanted this one to actually be useful... Something you’d come back to before your next carousel and walk away with a sharper draft.

If even one section saved you an hour of frustration, this playbook did its job.

If you have questions, want feedback on a draft, or want to talk about working together, **my DMs are open.**

Send me a note and tell me what you’re working on. I read everything.

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Editorial-led carousel designer for founders

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